The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Donald Trump threatened to strike Iranian power plants and bridges on Tuesday if Iran's regime did not "open the fuckin' strait". This is the third time Mr Trump has threatened to attack civilian infrastructure, something which is generally considered a war crime under international law. Earlier Mr Trump boasted about the rescue of an American airman shot down by Iran on Friday.

Meanwhile **Israel's** defence minister warned of intensifying attacks on assets related to **Iran's petrochemical industry**. He claimed that the sector, having generated roughly $18bn in two years, "directly serves" to finance Iranian missile production. On Saturday Iran reported that Israeli missiles had effectively shut down one of the country's largest petrochemical complexes and struck the area around its sole nuclear power-plant for the fourth time in the war.

Iran continued to strike energy facilities in Gulf countries. **Kuwait** said its state oil company had suffered "significant material losses" in drone attacks on Sunday. A day earlier Iran hit energy and water desalination plants in Kuwait. In the **United Arab Emirates** debris from missile interceptions caused fires at a petrochemical plant, forcing it to suspend operations.

Aleksandar Vucic, Serbia's president, said he had informed the **Hungarian** prime minister, **Viktor Orban**, about explosives found near a gas pipeline that links the countries. Hungary holds elections in a week, and Mr Orban's populist-nationalist party is currently behind in the polls. Opposition politicians accused his party of staging the incident and seeking to blame it on Ukraine, support for which it opposes.

The Democratic Republic of Congo made an agreement with the Trump administration to receive **migrants** deported from America, even if they came from third countries. The Congolese government said the first people will arrive this month. America has made similar deals with other African countries and last week made its first deportations to Uganda, sending eight people.

Pepsi canned its sponsorship of a big music festival in London over the appearance of **Ye**, formerly known as Kanye West, a controversial rapper. Ye has made antisemitic statements in the past and released a song called "Heil Hitler" (though he has apologised and denies being an antisemite). Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, has criticised the festival's decision to book Ye.

Pope Leo appealed for peace in his first Easter mass. The American pontiff said "Let those who have the power to unleash wars choose peace." He did not name any conflicts, but he has recently become more forthright in his condemnation of some of the Trump administration's policies. This month he will make his first trip as pontiff to Africa, an increasingly important part of the world for Roman Catholicism.

Word of the week: "workslop", the unnecessary AI-generated slop that is produced when bosses tell employees they must use the technology. Read Ethan Mollick's guest essay on why employers should treat AI as what it is: weird.

Photograph: Getty Images

OPEC increases oil production—on paper

Sunday’s monthly meeting of representatives from the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its allies, who are collectively responsible for 40% of all oil output, was closely watched—and of little consequence. With the Strait of Hormuz still largely closed, 15% of the world’s oil cannot reach its customers. OPEC’s decision in March to boost output by 206,000 barrels per day (about 0.2% of global supply) was barely a drop in the bucket. The oil shock has only intensified as more of the Gulf states’ energy assets have been dragged into the conflict. And because those states include OPEC’s most important members, additional production doesn’t mean much until the strait is passable once more.

When OPEC announced their decision on Sunday—to increase output by the same amount again next month—they admitted the move was mostly symbolic. The group stressed that it “takes a long time” and expense to restore damaged energy assets to full capacity, let alone increase it.

Photograph: EPA

The American pontiff’s first Easter

Pope Leo celebrated Easter mass on Sunday for the first time as leader of the world’s 1.4bn baptised Roman Catholics. In his traditional address afterwards—made to the world, as well as the city of Rome—Leo appealed for peace. “Let those who have weapons lay them down! Let those who have the power to unleash wars choose peace!”, he said. Leo did not mention the attack on Iran directly. But America’s first pope has recently become more forthright in his condemnation of some of the Trump administration’s policies.

In church politics, meanwhile, the 70-year-old pontiff has moved cautiously. Beyond filling his previous post, Leo has made only one high-level Vatican appointment since his election last May. And he has generally tried to appease the sensibilities of Catholic traditionalists without discarding the liberal approach of his predecessor, Francis, to such issues as immigration, climate and poverty. It is a delicate balancing act.

Photograph: AFP

Beating high egg prices

The price of eggs has fallen by around 60% in America since this time last year, when a dozen cost a record $6.23 on average. This will be a relief for Americans celebrating Easter with cakes, dyed eggs and other eggstravagances. An outbreak of avian flu has wiped out hundreds of millions of chickens in both America and Europe since 2022, squeezing egg supplies. To beat henflation, the Trump administration imported over 650% more eggs last year than the year before—many from Turkey (the country) and Brazil.

While the virus continues to rage, global flocks are slowly recovering. But the egg business is sensitive to the cost of electricity, needed to light barns, and grain, used for chicken feed. Prices in Europe remain high, and the war in Iran may batter the industry. This week an egg in the Netherlands cost a record €0.35 ($0.41)—bad news for those hoping to gorge on *Paashaasjes*, a bready bunny-shaped treat, this weekend.

Photograph: Getty Images

AI comes for the arts

Does it matter if artists use AI? Bob Dylan, an American songwriter and Nobel literature laureate, has started publishing short stories, audio essays and fictional letters by historical figures on Patreon, a subscription platform. Mr Dylan has not commented beyond some cryptic posts on social media. But his fans are getting stirred up because some of the audio recordings seem to have been generated by AI.

Bots are not talented artists, but they are not necessarily worse than humans. “Shy Girl”, a buzzy horror novel, was recently withdrawn by its publisher before its American release after vigilante readers with bot-busting software detected signs of machine involvement. (Mia Ballard, the author, denies using AI.) Lots of the prose was derivative, but some of it was good, and many readers enjoyed it. Expect plenty more such controversies. As a younger Mr Dylan wrote (himself): “You don’t need a weatherman, to know which way the wind blows.”

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Nancy Dixon, Kansas City, Missouri, America
Iskriyana Vasileva, Berlin, Germany
Dervla Batt, Dublin, Ireland

They gave the correct answers of John Stennis, George H.W. Bush, Harry Truman, Chester Nimitz and Gerald Ford. The theme is that they all have current US aircraft carriers named after them.

The questions were

Monday: Richard Nixon proposed which long-running Mississippi Senator, who suffered from poor hearing, as an intermediary who should listen to the Watergate tapes and summarise them for investigators?

Tuesday: Who served as both America's ambassador to the United Nations and director of the CIA in the 1970s?

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

Friday: Which American president pardoned Richard Nixon?

Hell is truth seen too late.

Thomas Hobbes